

Is a Graphic Design Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

8.4

AI EXPOSURE · PRODUCTION / EXECUTION DESIGN
where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in a design degree, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study design" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where design sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here. It is not a case for giving up on design: the protected end of this field is real, well paid, and reachable from where you are — but it has to be aimed at deliberately rather than drifted into.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Design isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 5.6 to 8.4, and much of where you land inside that range is still decided by moves in front of you. The catch is that the aiming has to be deliberate, because the old route — production work leading up to direction — is the specific thing that has broken. The second half of this guide is those moves.

One honest note. This is the field where the automatable layer isn't the paperwork around the work — it is the craft, the part most people came for. If that lands hard, it's worth knowing now, because it changes nothing about your ability and everything about how deliberately you have to steer. The section on when the automatable layer is the craft explains why, and steering on purpose is exactly what this guide is for.

The short answer

On production work, design is the single most exposed path in this index. The versions that hold up are specific — and the good news is that specific is still reachable from almost any starting point.

Production and execution design scores **8.4** out of 10 — the highest score of any career we measure. Creative direction scores **5.6**, and UX and product design **6.0**.

And here is what makes design different from every other exposed career in this index. Everywhere else, the automatable layer is the administrative shell around the work — nurses chart, doctors write notes, teachers mark. Automation removes something people resented.

In design, the automatable layer is the craft.

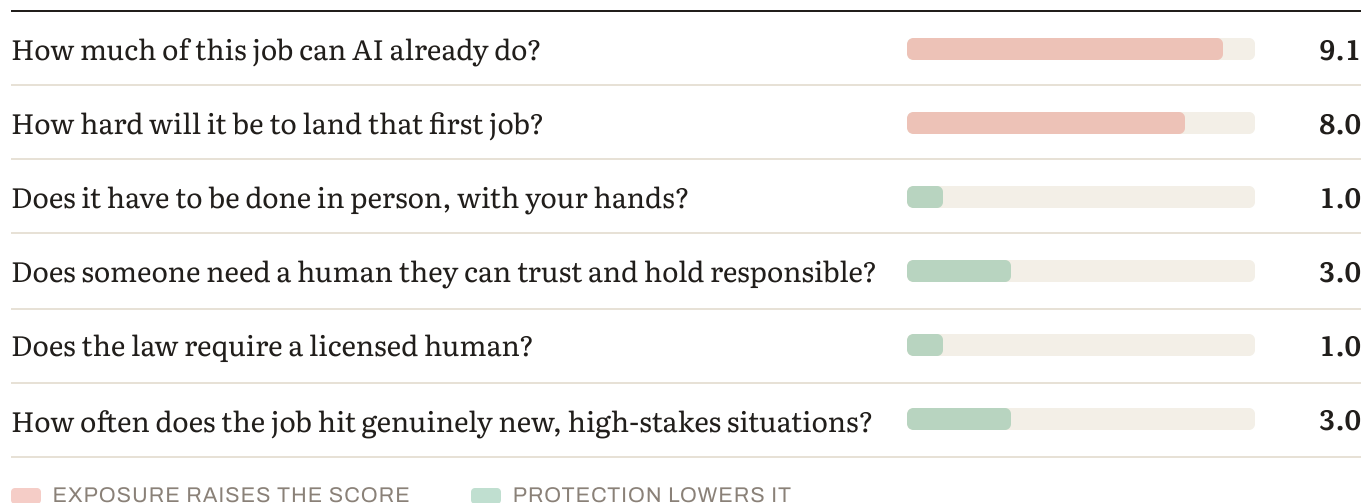
The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Creative direction / brand identity	4.8	5.2	5.6	+0.8	Moderate
UX / product design	5.2	5.6	6.0	+0.8	Moderate
Motion, 3D & technical craft	5.9	6.5	7.0	+1.1	Moderate-High
Illustration / commercial art	6.3	7.0	7.5	+1.2	High
Production / execution design	6.7	7.8	8.4	+1.7	Highest in the index

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, entry-level software development scores 8.1, content marketing 8.2, and general document translation 8.8.

Read the table this way: production design moved +1.7 in three years from an already elevated base, and it sits above entry-level software development. The gap between the top and bottom of this profession is 2.8 points — and your job, from here, is to move up the table toward direction and UX, not to hope the table moves.

Why design scores so high — the six factors



Here's how production and execution design answers them — the exposed end, and where most graduates start. Knowing *why* the production roles score 8.4 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

We rate this 9.1 — the highest rating we assign on any factor to any career in this index.

Image generation and asset creation. Layout, resizing and format variants. Routine illustration and stock work. Banner, social and ad production. Mockups and visual iteration. Photo retouching and cleanup.

The section on when the automatable layer is the craft explains why a 9.1 here means something different from a 9.1 anywhere else.

What resists: deciding what a brand should mean, art direction with intent, taste as a decision-making function, and defending a creative decision to a board. Those are the things to be building toward.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Severe.

Production and asset work was the entry tier — the work junior designers did while learning judgment. It is now the most automated work in this index.

Junior roles have also shifted in what they ask for. 32% of design job listings now mention AI tools such as Midjourney, Firefly or DALL·E, up from 3% in 2023, and 67% require Figma, up from 30% in 2021. The skill floor moved in under three years.

The way through isn't to wait for the production rung to come back — it may not. It's to enter beside it: aiming at UX, product or direction rather than assuming a production job leads there, attaching to a domain rather than staying generic, and carrying a portfolio of decisions instead of one that reads like everyone else's beautiful assets. That progression — production up to direction — is the specific thing that has broken, so the move is to aim past it. That's a set of concrete moves, not a hope, and the career-hunting checklist later in this guide lays them out.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

None of it, unless the physical object is the point — signage, print production, furniture, ceramics. Those are genuinely different careers.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At creative direction level meaningfully; at production level not at all.

A client betting a rebrand on someone's judgment wants a human accountable for it. Nobody is accountable for a resized banner.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

No, and none is coming. There is no design license, no reserved activity, no professional body controlling entry.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At direction level often; at production level rarely. A brand strategy for a company entering an unfamiliar market is genuine novelty. Producing forty variants of an approved asset is the opposite. The distance between those two is the distance you're trying to close.

When the automatable layer is the craft

This is the most important section in the guide, and the argument generalises beyond design.

Everywhere else in this index, automation removes the shell around the work.

Nurses chart. Doctors write notes and letters. Teachers plan and mark. Lawyers draft. Engineers document. In every one of those cases, the automatable layer is the part people resented, and removing it returns time to the thing they trained for.

Design is the exception.

Making the image. Building the layout. Producing the asset. That was not the paperwork around design — it *was* design. It's what people spend years learning to do well, and it's the part that made the job feel like a craft.

That's what a 9.1 means here. Not that the profession is worthless, but that the specific activity most designers spend most of their day performing is now something a non-designer can do adequately in seconds.

We rate it 9.1 rather than 10 because output quality still varies enormously with the skill of the person directing it, and because professional-standard work still requires judgment about what "good" looks like. But that judgment is a *directing* skill, not a *making* skill — and directing is a smaller job that fewer people are needed for.

This is also why creative direction sits at 5.6 rather than 8.4. Direction was never the automatable layer. It was always taste, intent and accountability, and none of those have moved much.

The general lesson, and it applies well beyond design: ask whether the automatable part of a job is the part you would enjoy. In most professions it isn't, and automation is a gift. In this one it is, and that changes the honest advice from "the field is fine" to "the field is fine and the job you pictured may not be."

The evidence that the split is already official

We'd normally put labor-market data in a later section. Here it belongs up front, because it independently confirms the central finding of this guide — and it comes from the US government rather than from us.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics tracks two separate occupational categories:

BLS CATEGORY	PROJECTED GROWTH 2024–2034	MEDIAN WAGE
Graphic Designers (SOC 27-1024)	+2% — slower than average	\$61,300
Web and Digital Interface Designers (SOC 15-1255)	+7% — much faster than average	roughly 60% higher

Same underlying skills. Different category. A 60% wage premium and more than triple the growth rate.

And the BLS says the quiet part out loud. Its own occupational outlook notes that *automated design tools, such as artificial intelligence, may reduce the need for companies to contract with freelance graphic designers*. Federal statistical agencies do not usually name a technology as a headwind for a specific occupation.

Corroborating it: the World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2025, surveying over 1,000 employers across 55 countries, flagged graphic designer among the fastest-declining job titles.

So the split this guide describes is not a prediction. It is already embedded in how the government counts the work.

What the trend shows

Production design: 6.7 → 7.8 → 8.4. Up 1.7 in three years, from a base that was already high.

Creative direction: 4.8 → 5.2 → 5.6. Up 0.8.

The gap widened from 1.9 points to 2.8. What is distinctive about design is that **the movement started earlier and from higher.** Most careers in this index show a step change after 2023. Design was already at 6.7 in 2023, because image generation reached commercial usability before text generation reached the professions.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Real at direction level	Durable	Clients want a person answerable for a brand decision. Commercially rooted.
Judgment under novelty	Real at direction level	Eroding slowly	Taste and intent resist; execution does not.
Regulatory / licensing	None	n/a	No license exists and none is coming.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Except where the object is the point — print, signage, craft.

The honest read. Design has two protections, both seniority-dependent, neither inherited from the profession. A graduate has neither, and the route to acquiring them ran through the production work that has been automated — which is exactly why the aiming has to be deliberate, and why the direction you steer matters more than where you happen to start.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Making the asset	Directing generation, then selecting and refining
Producing options	Choosing between fifty generated options
Learning taste by executing badly and being corrected	Learning taste by... curating? Nobody knows yet
Charging for time spent	Charging for judgment — a different business model
Deciding what the brand means	Unchanged

Two things worth naming.

The pricing model breaks. Design has historically been sold by time or by asset. When producing an asset takes minutes, the economics of the whole freelance market change — which is why the AIGA and Fast Company have run a pricing transparency study rather than a hiring one.

And the training problem is acute here. Designers built taste by making a great deal of mediocre work and being told why it was mediocre. If the making is automated, the correction loop that produced judgment is missing, and nobody has replaced it. Which means the designers who go out of their way to build judgment — seeking critique, chasing real briefs — have an edge that's about to get scarcer.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Taste as a decision** — knowing which of a thousand generated options is right for this brand, this market, this moment. The core of what survives. 2. **Intent** — being able to say why, and defend it. 3. **Accountability for a creative choice** — standing behind it when someone senior

pushes back. 4. **Understanding a business problem** — most bad design is a misunderstood brief rather than a poorly executed one. 5. **Directing generation precisely** — a genuine skill, and now explicitly named in a third of job listings.

Notably absent: software fluency, production speed, and volume of polished work. These were the traditional markers of a strong junior designer and are the fastest-depreciating things in the field. If your current value is mostly on that list, the work is to shift it onto the first one.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools — the generation models, Figma, whatever arrives next — will turn over many times across a career; the field's toolset consolidated in under three years, and it will move again. The designers who compound are the ones who stay genuinely curious about the problem and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of making they trained on. In a field with no license and no fixed toolkit, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and it's increasingly what employers are hiring for: the trajectory toward judgment, not the current making skill.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The industry is growing even as the job title contracts, and both things are true at once. Design services revenue continues to expand; what has changed is how much human production it requires per dollar.

- **Creative directors report a median around \$138,000**, and the senior end of this field is genuinely well paid
- **UX and product designers out-earn graphic designers substantially** — the roughly 60% BLS premium, and industry surveys put the gap higher still
- **Specialization pays**: freelance specialists report earning materially more than generalists
- **About 20,000 openings a year** are still projected for graphic designers, mostly from turnover rather than growth
- **Roughly one in five designers is self-employed**, which is high, and autonomy is one of the field's genuine attractions

And a finding worth sitting with. The 2026 Freelance Design Pricing study, run by Fast Company with AIGA across 1,426 respondents, found **nearly 40% of companies now use AI to**

start creative projects — but only 14% of hiring managers expect their need for freelance designers to shrink.

That gap is the most encouraging data point in this guide. It suggests AI is being used at the beginning of the process rather than instead of it — though it is a forecast by hiring managers rather than an observed outcome, and should be read as such.

What designers report as rewarding: making things that exist in the world and that people encounter, solving a communication problem elegantly, and the specific satisfaction of craft — which is precisely the part under pressure.

What's genuinely hard about it

The entry tier has been hollowed out, and it was the training ground.

The pricing model is under real strain. When production is fast and cheap, hourly billing collapses and value-based pricing requires a seniority and confidence most juniors don't have.

Portfolio expectations have inverted. Volume of polished work used to be the signal. **Volume is now free,** so a portfolio full of beautiful assets says nothing. What signals value is evidence of judgment — why this direction, what was rejected, what happened when it shipped.

And the emotional dimension is real and worth naming. People go into design because they love making things. Being told the making is the automated part lands differently from being told your paperwork is automated.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Design tends to reward people who:

- **Are interested in the problem, not just the artefact** — the single best predictor of who moves up rather than out
- **Can take criticism of work they care about,** repeatedly, without deflating
- **Can explain a choice,** not just make it. The whole protected end depends on this.
- **Are commercially curious** — design serves a business objective, and the designers who understand that get to direct

It's harder for people who:

- **Love the craft itself above all** — this is the honest one, and it's the group most affected
- Find **defending decisions** uncomfortable

- Want **stable, definable tasks**
- Are drawn to design as an escape from analytical work; the surviving end of this field is more analytical, not less

If some of that second list sounds like you, it isn't a reason to abandon the degree — it's a reason to steer toward the problem and away from the artefact, deliberately, which is what the rest of this does.

What else is moving this market

The tooling consolidated fast. Figma requirements went from 30% of listings in 2021 to 67% today. Sketch collapsed, InVision closed. The tool landscape is now stable in a way it wasn't.

Offshoring compounds automation at the production tier, as it does in accounting.

And the category migration is the thing to watch. Designers increasingly identify as UX, product, motion or interactive designers — categories BLS counts separately and projects growing. That migration is the profession's own answer to this problem, and it is already well underway.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: design was the first creative profession to be substantially affected, which means it is also furthest into working out what comes next. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a live studio project or first job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE DESIGNER LOOKS LIKE

- 1. Direct precisely.** Getting usable output requires knowing what to ask for, which requires knowing what good looks like. A third of job listings now name this explicitly.
- 2. Curate with judgment.** Choosing among generated options is the job now, and choosing well is a real and scarce skill.
- 3. Articulate the why.** Being able to defend a creative decision to a client or a board. This is the whole protected end of the field expressed as a skill.
- 4. Understand the business problem.** The designers who get to direct are the ones who understand what the work is for, rather than only how it should look.

5. Price judgment rather than time. The old model breaks when production is instant. Learning to sell outcomes rather than hours is a commercial skill the profession is actively rebuilding.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where a design degree can lead later

Broader than people assume: creative direction and brand strategy, UX and product design, design leadership, design research, motion and 3D, art direction, design operations, and founding a studio.

The pattern in this index holds precisely: roles where someone decides and is answerable score better; roles that produce what someone else decided score worse. In design that distinction is unusually stark, because the producing has become close to free. That gradient is the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: much of where you land is still decided by moves in front of you. Design is a 2.8-point spread from 5.6 to 8.4, and the difference between the protected end and the exposed one is not the school on your CV but the direction you steer from here — chiefly, away from production and toward judgment.

If you're still in the degree

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. Aim at UX, product or direction — the concentration is the whole game. The general degree pointed at production is the exposed one, the row that scores worst in this entire guide (8.4). The protected destinations — creative direction (5.6), UX and product design (6.0) — are reached by concentration, not by assuming production leads up to them, because that progression is precisely the one that has broken. If you haven't committed to a direction, this is the single highest-leverage decision left in the degree. The category migration BLS already counts — graphic design at +2%, web and digital interface design at +7% — is the profession's own answer; move with it.

2. A portfolio of decisions, while it's still cheap to build. Volume is now free, so a wall of polished assets says nothing about you. For every piece, be able to say what the problem was, what you rejected, and what happened when it shipped. That evidence of judgment is what separates the protected end from the exposed floor — and it is far easier to build inside a degree, with real briefs and real critique, than to assemble later.

3. Critique and a domain, earlier than feels comfortable. Defending a choice to a client or a board is the whole protected end expressed as a skill, and most programs underweight it — so chase every formal critique you can get. Alongside it, pair design with a domain — healthcare, accessibility, an industrial context — because the domain is the protection, and design paired with one is far more defensible than design alone.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early-career design titles are also the most exposed.

- **"Production designer" is the 8.4, and much commercial illustration the 7.5.** They're the default junior destinations and the automating layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
- **Aim at UX and product design (6.0), and creative-direction-adjacent roles (5.6).** More protected, growing rather than contracting, and the categories the profession is migrating into.
- **Attach to a domain, not "design in general."** Design paired with healthcare, accessibility or an industrial context inherits that field's protection. "Open to any design work" aims straight at the exposed end.
- **Chase the decision.** Anything where you decide and are answerable — often at a smaller studio or in-house team — moves you toward the protected end years sooner than producing what someone else decided at a big name.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't undo the way production automated, but you can be the designer who directs these tools rather than competes with them. The five capabilities above — direct precisely, curate with judgment, articulate the why, understand the business problem, price judgment rather than time — are all available right now, inside a current studio project or a first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is the pairing of the first two: be the person who directs generation precisely and curates the result with judgment — and can show the decision behind every choice. In a field where volume is free, a portfolio of decisions is the credential — and it's one you can start building this term, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in design is built here, in these habits and choices, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree — build what can't be automated

- **Aim at UX, product or direction from the start.** The exposed lane is the general degree pointed at production work — the weakest combination in this index (8.4). UX / product (6.0) and creative direction (5.6) are reached by concentration, not by assuming production leads there. That progression is precisely the one that has broken.
- **Build a portfolio of decisions, not assets.** Volume is now free, so a wall of beautiful assets says nothing. For every piece, be able to say what the problem was, what you rejected, and what happened when it shipped. Evidence of judgment is the credential.
- **Chase critique, and learn to defend a choice.** Defending decisions to a client or a board is the whole protected end expressed as a skill, and most programs underweight it — so pursue every formal critique you can get.
- **Attach to a domain.** Design paired with healthcare, accessibility or an industrial context inherits that field's protection and is far more defensible than design alone. The domain is the protection.
- **Get fluent directing generation, not competing with it.** Learn to direct precisely and curate with judgment — a third of listings now name this explicitly — and be able to show the decision behind the output, not just the output.
- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The tools consolidated in under three years and will move again; the designer who stays curious about the problem and re-tools fastest compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet the adjacent versions — UX and product specifically, a domain pairing, or craft where the physical object is the point — before ruling them out. The most crowded lane is the default production one.

During the job hunt — aim, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** UX and product design (6.0), creative-direction-adjacent roles (5.6), a domain-paired seat — not "graphic designer, open to anything,"

which points straight at the 8.4.

- **Read the title, not just the offer.** "Production designer" and much commercial illustration are the automating layer (8.4 and 7.5). If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, not as the plan.
 - **Don't grab a job just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. An employer still running a large production or asset-making intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung that gets cut first once they catch up. Availability today can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
 - **Prefer the decision, and the smaller room.** A role where you decide and are answerable — often at a smaller studio or in-house team — puts you close to the protected end years sooner than producing what someone else decided at a big name.
 - **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** How they answer reveals whether they're building the job around directing and judgment or waiting to be forced to. You want the former; it's the difference between a role that grows and one that's quietly being hollowed out.
 - **Weigh the trajectory over the starting salary.** A role that builds judgment, direction and a portfolio of decisions beats a higher-paid production seat in a lane that's being automated underneath you.
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Go deeper — further reading

- **Graphic Designers — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — US Bureau of Labor Statistics. The primary source, free, and unusually direct: it names automated design tools as a factor reducing demand for freelance designers. Read it alongside the separate **Web and Digital Interface Designers** entry, and note the difference in projected growth. That comparison is the single most useful thing in this guide.
- **Freelance design in 2026: how to set fees, wrangle clients, and navigate AI** — Fast Company with AIGA, 1,426 respondents including 153 hiring companies. The source of the 40%-versus-14% finding, and the best available picture of what is actually happening to design pricing.
- **Is graphic design a good career in 2026?** — a careful, sourced treatment of the BLS category split and what it means in practice. Note it's published by a design college, so read the framing critically — but the underlying data is cited properly.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our 8.4 is historical, and it has a good record.

When desktop publishing arrived, designers feared replacement by "anyone with a mouse." The field expanded instead, and produced entirely new subfields — UX, digital branding, product design — that hadn't previously existed. On this reading, generative AI is the next iteration of a tool shift the profession has repeatedly absorbed, and our score mistakes a transition for a collapse.

There's live evidence for it too: nearly 40% of companies use AI to start creative projects, and only 14% of hiring managers expect to need fewer freelance designers.

Where we land: we take it seriously, and it's part of why direction sits at 5.6 rather than 8. But there's a difference worth naming between a tool that changes *how* work is produced and one that produces the work itself. Photoshop still needed a designer at the keyboard for every asset. Generation does not.

The honest position is that we don't know whether new creative categories will appear fast enough to absorb the displaced production tier. History says probably something will, and offers no guarantee about timing. **A graduate needs a job in the meantime, and the transition is exactly when the pain lands.**

Bottom line

Design is the most exposed career in this index, and it is not a dead end — which is exactly why being already in it is not a problem. The decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

Production work — the thing most people picture when they say "graphic designer" — scores 8.4 and is the most automated professional work we measure. Creative direction at 5.6 and UX at 6.0 are real, well-paid, growing careers, and they are reachable from where you stand.

The government's own data already reflects the split. Graphic Designers projected to grow 2%; Web and Digital Interface Designers 7%, at roughly a 60% wage premium. **The migration between those categories is the answer, and it's already happening — move with it.**

What makes design genuinely different is the emotional shape of it. In most professions automation takes the part people resented. Here it takes the craft — the thing that made the job feel worth doing. That's worth acknowledging honestly rather than reframing as opportunity.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Aim at direction, UX or a domain pairing rather than assuming production work leads there. Build a portfolio of decisions rather than assets. Learn to defend choices, because that's the protected skill. And build real AI fluency now, inside whatever project or role you're in, directing generation rather than competing with it — because that's the differentiator this field rewards fastest.

And one thing worth holding onto if you love making things. The judgment about what should exist is now worth more than the ability to make it, and that judgment is built by people who care about craft. The path is narrower than it was. It hasn't closed — and you're already on it.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in the degree or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which direction are you pointed at — and is it *production* (making the asset, 8.4) or *judgment* (direction and UX, 5.6 and 6.0)? 2. Looking at the score table, which destination are you currently on track for, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. Does your portfolio show decisions — the problem, what you rejected, what shipped — or only polished assets? If it's the latter, what's the nearest way to change that?

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected role you could realistically aim for from where you are now — a UX, product or direction-adjacent seat — and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: how much formal critique are you actually getting, and is there a UX, product or domain pathway still open to you? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a protected lane on purpose, or applying to whatever's open? Name the three roles you're actually chasing.

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — direct precisely, curate with judgment, articulate the why, understand the business problem, price judgment rather than time — which one could you visibly demonstrate within the next few months? 8. Can you point to a single piece where you

directed generation and can show the decision behind it — why this, what you rejected? If not, what would be the easiest one to start with?

Testing it against reality

9. The most valuable single action: find a designer two to three years in and ask what they actually do all day, and what changed in the last eighteen months. **10.** If the first offer that comes is a "production designer" role, what's your plan — take it as a deliberate stepping-stone with an exit in mind, or hold out for something closer to direction? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation, not a guarantee or a prediction. For design specifically, we've published the historical counterargument in full because it has a good track record, and we don't know whether it applies this time.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Graphic & Visual Design

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

CREATIVE DIRECTION / BRAND IDENTITY — 5.6 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.0	4.9	5.9	2.06
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	4.0	4.5	0.67
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	5.62 → 5.6

UX / PRODUCT DESIGN — 6.0 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.6	5.5	6.4	2.24
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.0	4.5	5.0	0.75
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.45
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.0	7.0	7.0	0.3
				Total	5.99 → 6.0

MOTION, 3D & TECHNICAL CRAFT — 7.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.3	6.7	7.8	2.73
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.0	5.8	6.5	0.97
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.5	5.5	5.5	0.45
				Total	7.01 → 7.0

ILLUSTRATION / COMMERCIAL ART — 7.5 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.5	7.1	8.2	2.87
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.5	7.2	1.08
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.55
				Total	7.5 → 7.5

PRODUCTION / EXECUTION DESIGN — 8.4 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.9	7.4	8.7	3.04
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.5	8.0	9.0	1.35
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	3.0	3.0	3.0	1.05
Regulatory / licensing	10%	1.0	1.0	1.0	0.9
Judgment under novelty	10%	3.0	3.0	3.0	0.7
				Total	8.39 → 8.4

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Creative direction / brand identity

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.0	3.5	2.88	4.8
2025	4.9	4.0	2.88	5.2
Fall 2026	5.9	4.5	2.88	5.6

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed +0.67 and entry-path erosion +0.15, for a total of +0.8 points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.